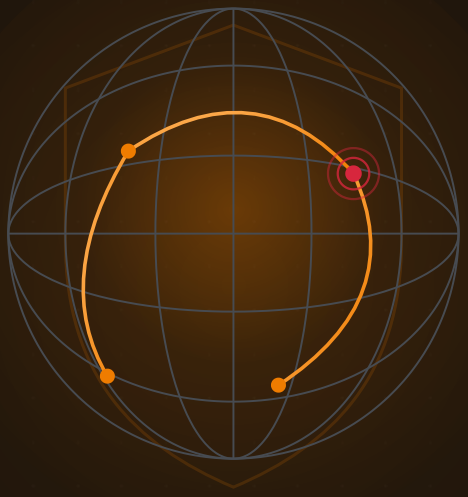
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EDITION 14
26 OCTOBER 2026



THREAT PULSE

WEEKLY CYBER THREAT BRIEFING

WEEK IN REVIEW · 19 – 25 OCTOBER 2026

A critical flaw in PHP, the engine behind much of the web, is being attacked — plus a Microsoft 365 backup-tool breach, a leaky cloud hosting platform and a trust scare over weak website-certificate keys.

Prepared by DPG-Cyber
Client threat intelligence

Welcome to **Threat Pulse**, your plain-English weekly round-up of the cyber threats making waves worldwide. This week's standout story is **"PHP2Shell"**: two critical flaws in **PHP**, the software that powers a huge share of the world's websites, which attackers began probing days before a fix existed. We also cover a breach of **ConnectWise** backup tools used with **Microsoft 365**, a cloud-hosting platform called **Railway** and weak security keys at a certificate provider. No jargon, just practical steps.

AT A GLANCE THIS WEEK

9.2 /10
Severity of this week's PHP flaws (critical)

5.1M+
PHP web servers visible on the internet

4 days
Attack attempts seen before the fix

THIS WEEK'S HEADLINE THREAT

PHP "PHP2SHELL" · CVE-2026-109618 & CVE-2026-109619

Critical PHP flaws let attackers run commands on web servers — no login needed



CRITICAL

Exploitation: **attack attempts seen from 17 Oct; working exploit exists (not yet on US CISA's exploited list)**

WHAT'S HAPPENING

On **21 October 2026** the PHP project released emergency fixes for two flaws (**CVE-2026-109618** and **CVE-2026-109619**, each rated **9.2 out of 10**). PHP is the language behind countless websites. The flaws let an outsider with **no username or password** take over a vulnerable web server with a single specially crafted request. Amazon's security team saw the first attack attempts on **17 October**, four days before the fix.

WHO'S AFFECTED

Any website or application running **PHP** without the new update — researchers estimate **over 5 million** PHP servers are visible online. **Palo Alto Networks** firewalls (no fix yet) and **Cisco Expressway** are also affected.

WHY IT MATTERS TO YOU

If your website, online portal or customer system runs on PHP, an attacker could **take control of the server** behind it — to steal customer data or attack others. Most activity so far looks like probing, but the UK's NCSC urges organisations to update at once or take unpatched systems offline.

Good news: fixed PHP versions are available now (8.5.12, 8.4.27, 8.3.36 and 8.2.35), and Cloudflare has switched on protective rules for all customers. If you do not run your own website or servers, you need do nothing.

What to do about the headline threat

- [ ] **Ask your web team or hosting provider to update PHP today** and confirm the new version number for every site you run.
- [ ] **If a site cannot be updated yet,** ask for web-firewall protection or to take it offline until it can.
- [ ] **Ask IT to check for signs of tampering** in website logs from 17 October onward, and to update any Palo Alto or Cisco Expressway devices.

OTHER THREATS WORTH KNOWING ABOUT

HIGH

ConnectWise breach gave China-linked spies a way into Microsoft 365 accounts

Microsoft says a China-aligned group (**Storm-0940**) stole access credentials belonging to **ConnectWise** cloud backup and security apps, then tried to sign in to **more than 2,250 Microsoft 365 organisations** — at times nearly 3,000 attempts a minute. Most failed; ConnectWise has shut the services down.

Takeaway: if your IT provider uses ConnectWise backup tools, ask them to review your Microsoft 365 for unfamiliar apps and permission changes.

HIGH

Cloud hosting platform Railway may have leaked customers' stored passwords and keys

On 21 October **Railway**, a platform developers use to run apps, found that an outsider may have accessed — and for some customers **decrypted** — stored "environment variables", which often hold **access keys and database passwords**. Railway urged every customer to replace their stored secrets.

Takeaway: if your developers or suppliers use Railway, ask that every stored key and password is changed now.

MEDIUM

Weak security keys at a certificate provider force emergency browser updates

Eight security keys belonging to **eMudhra**, an Indian provider of the digital certificates behind the browser padlock, turned out to be so weak they could be guessed. In theory they could be used to impersonate websites. **Firefox, Chrome and Apple** have blocked the certificates; there is no evidence of misuse.

Takeaway: keep browsers and operating systems up to date this week so the block applies to you.

Your 3-minute checklist this week

- [ ] Ask your web team or host whether your sites run **PHP** — and that it has been **updated this week**.
- [ ] Ask whether your IT provider uses **ConnectWise** backup tools, and have them review Microsoft 365 app permissions.
- [ ] If you or your suppliers use **Railway**, change every stored key and password now.
- [ ] Ask IT for a list of the **suppliers and tools with access** to your systems.

Threat Pulse is provided by DPG-Cyber for general awareness only and does not constitute specific security or legal advice. Threat details are drawn from reputable public reporting as at 26 October 2026 and may evolve as investigations continue. For guidance tailored to your environment, please contact your DPG-Cyber account team.

BEHIND THE HEADLINES

Why a watchful eye changes the outcome

Every threat in this issue had one thing in common: the damage happens in the **quiet gap between the break-in and the moment someone notices**. Tools alone rarely stop an attack — what limits the harm is continuous monitoring that correlates the signals, spots the intrusion early, and responds before a foothold becomes a crisis.

247 days

Average time for organisations to identify *and* contain a breach

SOURCE: IBM COST OF A DATA BREACH 2026

$4.99M

Global average total cost of a single data breach

SOURCE: IBM COST OF A DATA BREACH 2026

THE WINDOW THAT MATTERS

Intrusion	Foothold	Lateral movement	Impact
the way in	quietly settling in	spreading across systems	data theft / ransomware

The sooner an attack is spotted, the smaller the damage. Closing this window — detecting and responding on the left, long before impact on the right — is the entire job of a Security Operations Centre.

WHAT CONTINUOUS MONITORING QUIETLY DOES

Sees across everything

A SIEM gathers and correlates activity from across your systems, so unusual behaviour stands out instead of hiding in the noise.

Watches around the clock

Attacks don't keep office hours. A SOC means real people monitoring day, night and weekends — not just 9 to 5.

Knows the latest tactics

Fresh threat intelligence — like the PHP and supplier-access attacks in this issue — feeds detection so new tricks are recognised fast.

Acts, not just alerts

Alerts are triaged and investigated by analysts who step in early, turning a would-be incident into a non-event.

CLIENT ACTION OF THE WEEK

THIS WEEK'S FIX

Update PHP on every website you run

Ask your web team or hosting provider to move to **PHP 8.5.12, 8.4.27, 8.3.36 or 8.2.35** (or the provider's patched equivalent) today, and confirm in writing that each site has been done.

GOOD HABIT

Check your suppliers' access

List the suppliers and tools that can reach your systems or cloud accounts, and ask how they protect that access. This week's ConnectWise and Railway incidents show a **supplier's breach can become yours**.

This is the quiet, everyday work behind **DPG-Cyber's SIEM & SOC services** — the same monitoring and response that turns headlines like these into non-events for the businesses we look after. If you're ever curious how it would map to your own environment, we're always happy to talk it through, no pressure — just drop us a line at **hello@dpg-cyber.com**.